Tips for Handling APS Special Collections

Adapted from Yale University Library Preservation and Conservation

Keep these tips in mind for all types of collections material:

- Always handle materials with clean, dry hands (use gloves for photographs, glass, and metals).
- Take a breath. Approach material in a calm, relaxed manner. Ask for help if you feel uncertain.
- Look before you leap: Look for vulnerable spots on the item like tears, bends, or loose media.
- If you pick something up, always make sure you have a clear, safe space to put the item down.
- Make sure your path is clear of obstructions before moving collections material.
- Faster is not better — speedy handling can cause accidents! Handle material slowly and carefully.
- Make sure that jewelry, badges, scarves, and neckties do not dangle over or brush material.
- Avoid placing anything other than weights on top of collection material. Do not lean or rest on it.
- Make sure you have a clean, dry workspace free of dust and debris.
- Support material at all times by resting it directly, and fully, on a table or foam supports.

HANDLING TOOLKIT

****Blue text indicates a tool that may be needed in some circumstances.***

Book cradles 

Flat foam book rest 

Book weights 

Nitrile gloves 

Support board *(large enough to support the item)* 

Micro spatula 

Snakes 

You may need a cart 

Brittle paper & Newsprint:

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Handle only when necessary (e.g., to move from one place to another).
- Use a folder or box to support and handle brittle paper or newsprint.
- Keep paper flat on work surface.
- Avoid unfolding if possible; ask for assistance if needed.
- Turn pages starting at the top right corner, using your whole hand to turn the page rather than grasping just the corner.
- Avoid turning the page from the bottom as pages are more likely to tear when turned from the bottom.

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Paper itself is vulnerable; handle with care.
- Corners, folds, and creases
- Tears or breaks

TOOLS NEEDED    *for picking up the corner of the sheet*

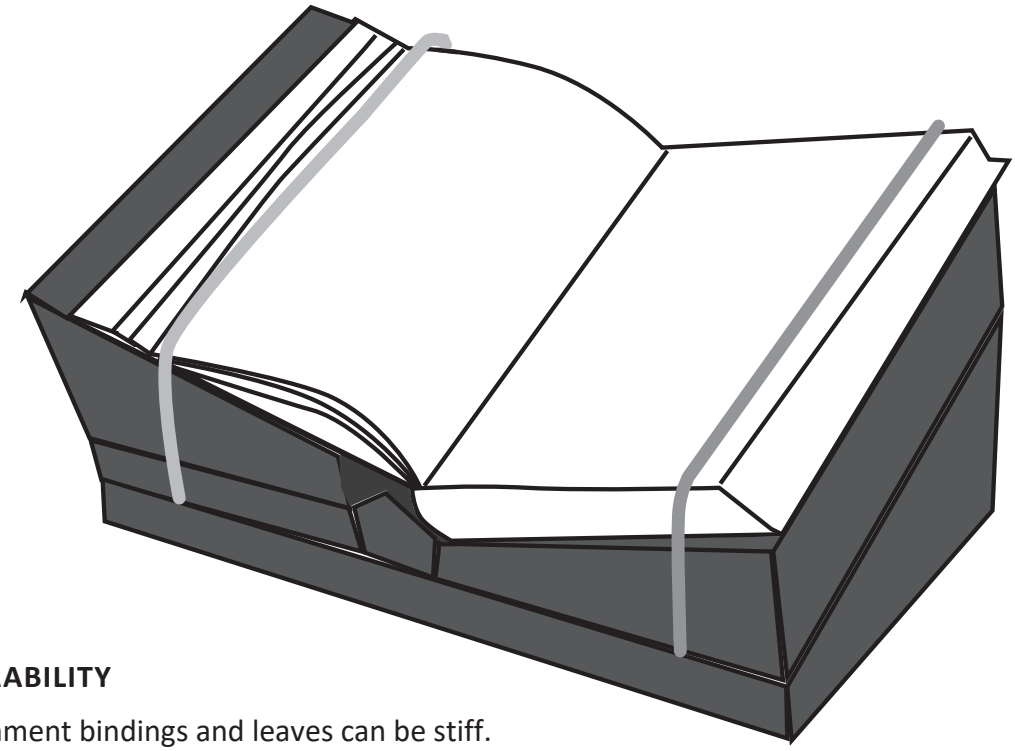
Bound Volumes (paper, leather, and vellum bound):

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Use book cradles and foam planks for all books, but especially to support books that cannot fully open or have broken bindings (e.g., loose boards, loose text block).
- Avoid forcing open volumes that have stiff or tight bindings. Stop at the point of resistance.
- Turn pages starting at the top right corner, using your whole hand to turn the page rather than grasping just the corner. Avoid turning the page from the bottom, as pages are more likely to tear this way.

Medieval Manuscripts

- Never touch the illuminations, and avoid touching the manuscript lettering.
- Touch only the blank margin area to turn the pages.
- Do not attempt to fasten binding clasps.



POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Vellum and parchment bindings and leaves can be stiff.
- Watch for brittle paper, tears, and breaks in the page.
- Boards may be partially or fully detached from the text block.
- Headcaps (spine tops) are often fragile and easily damaged; do not pull.
- Painted surfaces are inflexible, especially on parchment and vellum.

TOOLS NEEDED





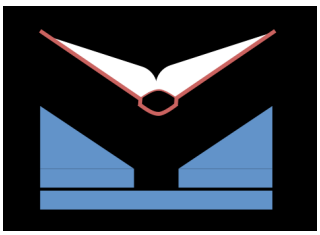

for turning brittle or fragile paper

TIPS FOR BOOK CRADLES

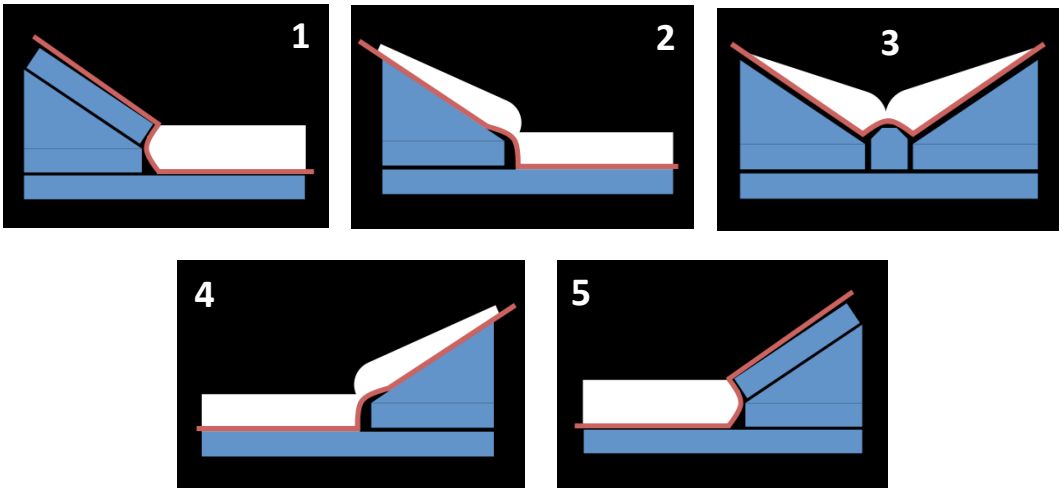
- Always support the wedges of the cradle on a wider foam plank.
- Use wedges and additional foam planks to support the boards and the spine of the book. ! Ř⁄dzăű I·ă ýŜŜŘŜŘ ű2 Y I·ű0K űKŜ ō2⁄2⁀ 2LJŜyλyƎ℗
- Bigger books may have enough weight to shove the wedges out of place even with the foam plank underneath. Tie cotton tape around the wedges if needed.
- If pages will not lie flat for reading, weigh them down at the edges with book snakes.



Large, heavy tightback books (where the leather is attached to the spine of the text block) require a foam spine piece to support the spine as it arches up.



For hollow-back books (where the spine is rigid and unattached to the spine of the text block), leave a gap between the halves of the cradle.



TIPS FOR BOOK PILLOWS

- Book pillows can be manipulated to fit the unique needs of a given book and won't shift easily when flipping pages.
- Choose a pillow that closely matches the book's size. Ideally, there should be at least 1 inch of pillow visible around the perimeter of the book.
- Adjust the material inside the pillow so it supports the book fully.
- Store cradles, pillows, and sofas with care. Bring any soiled or deteriorating cradles, pillows, sofas, or weights to the attention of Conservation.





Foldouts:

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- See how the item is folded up before attempting to unfold it.
- Unfold slowly and carefully.
- Use a horizontal support card for large foldouts and place it behind an adjacent page, rather than directly behind the foldout.
- Weights and snakes may be used to keep foldouts open, if needed.
- *Always ask a librarian for help; sometimes more than two hands are needed.*

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Watch the area where the foldouts attach to the book — tears often start here from mishandling.
- The folded areas of the foldout may be weaker than the rest of the sheet due to repeated unfolding and refolding.
- Foldouts are not always printed on the same type of paper as the text block — some can be very lightweight and delicate, while others may be heavyweight and stiff.

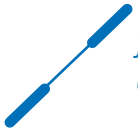
TOOLS NEEDED







large enough to support the foldout



for turning brittle or fragile paper

Oversized maps, posters, artwork, and broadsides:

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Use a support board and/or cart to transport item from storage to reading room.
- Lift oversized paper from corner to corner on a diagonal, using two hands and opposite corners.

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Damaged or weak corners
- Torn or brittle paper
- Look for loose pieces on collages and other multimedia works.
- Avoid touching image areas; some media can be smudged when touched (e.g., charcoal, soft pencil, chalk, and pastels).

TOOLS NEEDED





Photographs on Paper:

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Always handle with nitrile gloves (if photograph is not in plastic sleeve).
- Never touch the surface of a photograph: handle the item by its edges.
- Always lift photograph with two hands, holding its opposite edges.
- Photographs should not be removed from plastic sleeves.
- When carrying large photographic prints, make sure the print is fully supported by carrying it on a board, folder, or inside a box.

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

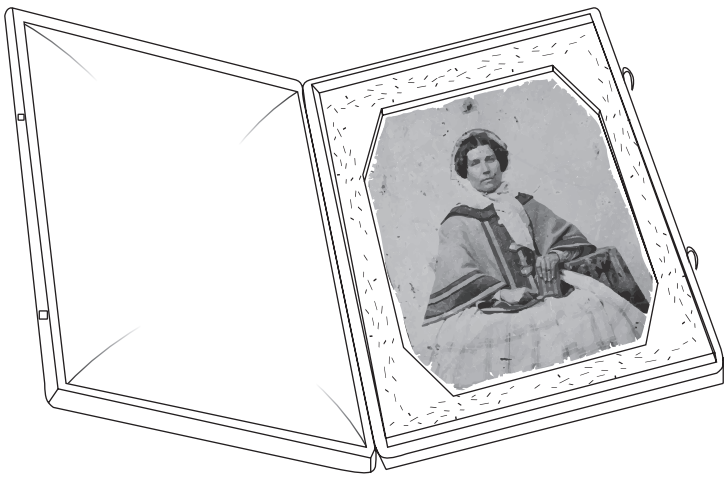
- Brittle mounts or paper, especially on corners
- Image surface is prone to abrasion.
- Do not bend or fold — paper/board may be more brittle than image surface or vice versa.
- Photographs can crack if folded or tightly rolled — this is because they are made up of multiple layers of different types of material. Do not force photographs open.

TOOLS NEEDED



for photographs not in Mylar sleeves

Cased Photographs:



TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Use both hands to support the halves of the case.
  - Avoid placing weight directly on the hinge.
- Do not close clasp or fastener when returning case to its housing container.
- Handle on or directly over a soft surface.
- Do not remove glass photograph package from case.
  - Glass photograph package removal requires curatorial permission and conservation intervention.

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Cover glass is fragile — it may be cracked or broken.
- Hinge may be fragile or broken.
- Clasp or fastener may be fragile or loose.
- Deteriorating, flaking leather or cracked plastic case

TOOLS NEEDED

Glass Plate Negatives and Lantern Slides:

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Wear nitrile gloves when handling.
- Always handle glass on or directly over a soft surface.
- Handle one plate at a time.
- Do not stack plates on top of one another.
- Handle plates by two opposite edges; never hold them by one edge, or by the corners.
- Place glass plates emulsion (matte) side up when you lay them flat on a surface.
    - Check for glass reflectance to find the non-emulsion (shiny) side of the plate.
- Do not press, lean, or write on top of the glass plate.



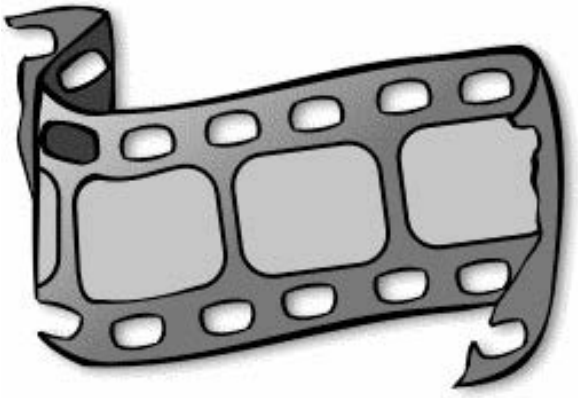
POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Flaking or lifted emulsion layer (the dull, top layer that holds the image)
- Glass may be chipped, cracked, or broken

TOOLS NEEDED



Microfilm:



TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Microfilm is often aging and fragile, so exercise caution.
- Wear nitrile gloves if you must touch an image area of the film.
- Avoid using the **rewind** function on microfilm readers, which requires the carriage to be pulled out. Use the **fast rewind** function, which is safer.
- Notify conservators if microfilm needs mending.

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Aging film may be warped, brittle, and smell of vinegar.
- Matte emulsion side of film is vulnerable to abrasion.

TOOLS NEEDED



Rolls & Scrolls:

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Make sure there is sufficient space to unroll the item safely.
- Check for damaged or weak edges.
- *Slowly* unroll item and use weights to hold down the free exposed edge of the roll.

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Edges may be damaged or weak.
- Media may be cracked or friable.
- Use caution when placing weights on object; avoid vulnerable areas.
- Tightly rolled papers may be difficult to lay flat; use caution when unrolling, especially brittle, fragile items.

TOOLS NEEDED



Framed Works, Paintings, & Two-Dimensional Artwork*:

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Always carry framed work vertically, unless item is damaged or vulnerable - then use a flat cart.
- Lift with two hands holding the top and bottom of the frame, OR
    - For large pieces, use two people to move painting from one place to another, using an A-frame cart, or a flat cart, image side up.
- Avoid touching image area (if no glass); some media can be smudged when touched (e.g., charcoal, soft pencil, chalk, and pastels).
- If parts of the image have become detached, ensure that loose pieces are returned to the enclosure.

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Glass/ glazing on framed items is fragile.
- Some frames can be fragile, especially older ones or heavily adorned/ gilded frames.
- Watch for saggy or loose canvas on paintings.
- Look for loose pieces on collages and other multimedia works.
- Watch for hanging hardware as it may be loose/ brittle and/or catch on clothing or scratch.

TOOLS NEEDED



*APS Museum artifacts may be viewed with Museum staff upon request.

Objects & 3D Works of Art*:

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Handle metal objects with nitrile gloves.
- Handle carefully, holding and lifting the object by the base or by its strongest point.
- Lift from the base of the object; avoid lifting object by any available handles.
- Move heavy or awkwardly sized objects with two people.

POINTS OF VULNERABILITY

- Glass, ceramic, and stone can have slick, polished surfaces — use a cart to reduce risk of dropping objects.
- Cracks, breaks, and chips
- Watch for small, fragile pieces or protrusions on object.

TOOLS NEEDED







if object needs to rest on its side

*APS Museum artifacts may be viewed with Museum staff upon request.

Potential Hazards in the Collections

CONTACT CONSERVATION IF YOU FIND ANY OF THE FOLLOWING:

- Mold, particularly with fuzzy surface growth, either dry or damp
- Books from the 1840s–1860s with bright green cloth covers, which may contain emerald green, a pigment made with arsenic
- Negative films or microfilms that smell like vinegar or are yellowed
- Unusual spotting or staining, as historic pest control measures included the use of mercury and arsenic in fumes or sprays

Mold images

TIPS FOR HANDLING

- Always wash your hands before and after handling collections.

Contact Conservation

Renée Wolcott: 215-440-3413 (call) or 919-523-8975 (text)
Fleur van der Woude: 215-440-3412 (call) or Google chat (fvanderwoude@amphilsoc.org)

At your desk:

- Make sure you have a clean, dry workspace free of dust and debris.
- Make sure your hands are clean, dry, and free of lotion and nail polish. Soap and water is preferable to hand sanitizer, which leaves a residue.
- Use nitrile gloves for photographs, glass, and metals.
- Use pencils rather than pens.
- Keep your closed water bottle on a separate surface from collections materials, such as a different table or the floor.
- Make sure that jewelry, badges, scarves, and neckties do not dangle over or brush material.
- Do not lean or rest on collection materials, or write on papers placed on top of them.
- Do not use tape, rubber bands, sticky notes, or document-repair tapes on collection items or enclosures.
- Use cotton tape to keep parts of a book together.
- When materials are not in use, keep them covered with a folder or protective piece of paper and a "collections below" sign.

When shelving:

- Shelve books so they are snug: not loose enough to lean, not so tight that they become hard to remove from the shelf.
- Do not force oversize materials to fit on standard shelves. Alert Conservation to miniature items that can disappear on the shelves.
- Use bookends appropriately, next to hardcover books that are not too fragile or too small. Use care when adding bookends to shelves to avoid catching and tearing leaves.
- If you are moving books around on shelves, use foam blocks to fill up temporary gaps while you move items around.
- Do not store or box a book spine up, as gravity will pull the text block out of the binding. If you must, store oversize books spine down, or find a shelf that fits the books better.
- Do not let materials hang over the edges of shelves, particularly in compact shelving. When you see something protruding beyond the shelf, gently push it back in or find a new home for it.

When paging or moving materials:

- Have an empty book truck or other lay-down space nearby.
- Use a step stool if you need one, or ask for help.
- Never pull a book from its shelf by the top of the spine (headcap), which may tear. Instead, push in the books on either side and grip the spine in the middle. If this doesn't work, reach over the book and push it out by the fore-edge.
- Before carrying a folder vertically, make sure the most intact edge of the document inside is touching the gutter (fold) of the folder.
- Always move oversize materials on wide carts or in portfolio cases. Do not carry them by hand or allow them to drape off the edges of a cart. Bring a second person to open doors for you.
- Place torn or weak papers on a support (folder or paperboard) when moving them.

Pest Management

Preventing Collections Damage in Your Workspace



Integrated pest management (IPM) limits damage to collections due to pest activity and increases safety for staff and visitors by reducing the use of pesticides. We all share responsibility for a pest-free work and collection environment. Keep collection areas and workspaces clean, and remember that dust and dead insects—even benign ones—provide a food source for other pests.

Principles of IPM

Discourage

Keep conditions in collection areas unattractive to pests: cool, dry, clean, well-ventilated, and free of food and food waste.

Block

Add physical barriers to pest entry (e.g., install door sweeps, make sure drain traps are full of water). Ensure that bugs don't hitch a ride in personal belongings or in infested collections and packing materials.

Detect

Regularly inspect collections areas and new accessions for early signs of pest activity so infestations don't spread.

Confine

When unusual concentrations of pests are discovered, block their spread to other areas of the building and collections.

Treat

Sometimes treatment is simple, such as removing a food source, stopping a water leak, or adding targeted pheromone traps. When absolutely necessary, pest infestations may be treated with chemical means, but this is a hazard to both people and collections.

How you can help

- Keep water bottles closed and isolated from surfaces with collections on them. No other beverages are permitted in collections spaces.
- Do not eat or store food in collections areas. Dispose of food waste in kitchens and staff lounges.
- In buildings where mice take shelter in winter, keep any food in pest-proof bins (heavy-duty plastic or metal).
- Clean up immediately after catered events in the reading room or board room, and isolate collections from surfaces where food is consumed during tours.
- Do not re-purpose cardboard boxes from basements or attics to pack new accessions, as silverfish and other bugs love to hitch a ride in the corrugations.
- Inspect new collections to ensure that they do not contain pre-existing mold or pest infestations.
- Examine incoming parcels and bags for insect activity, including insect tunnels, frass (gritty powder or bug excrement), and dark brown liquid stains (roach attar). Report to Conservation.
- Keep doors and windows closed, and alert Facilities to areas where bugs gain entry.
- Regularly monitor collections areas and other building spaces for signs of insect activity and alert Conservation to bug and rodent sightings or signs of pest activity (frass, webbing, mouse or roach pellets, etc.).
- Do not move or discard the sticky blunder traps that help conservators and pest technicians identify the insect species active within our buildings. Tracking pest data helps alert conservation to unusual trends.
- Let Facilities and Conservation know if a snap trap for rodents requires disposal.